

What Dungeons & Dragons Taught Me About Facilitation

James Colp
Mgr. Technology & Development | Dungeon Master

James Colp

Mgr. Technology & Development | Dungeon Master

PRAIRIE DEV CON

AI | CLOUD | DEV | DATA



Payworks



Google Public Sector | carahsoft.

NMM New Media
Manitoba

improving
It's what we do.™

laivly

POLLARD
banknote limited

RICHARDSON

Character Sheet

Manager, Technology & Development



Business Systems Consultant



PSHCP Program Analyst



Business Systems Analyst



Software Developer



James Colp (he/him)– Medium humanoid (Human)

Armor Class: 18 Hit Points: 78 (10d8 + 20)

Affiliations: WCLC, Judo Manitoba



Husband & Cat Dad (Toast & Mochi)



Judo Athlete, Coach, Referee



Backcountry Enthusiast



Dungeon Master



You're approached by a strange hooded figure ...

The individual begins to read off a crumpled lottery ticket, from his poorly scribbled ponderings

- What is Dungeons & Dragons “D&D”
- How can this possibly apply to my work?
- What are the similarities between DM'ing and facilitating?
 - Player / Participant engagement?
 - Facilitation tools & methods?
 - Pitfalls & lessons learned?



Initiative Order - how we proceed

1. D&D Overview
2. Rolling characters | Selecting participants
3. Prepping for a session | Preparing to facilitate
4. Dm'ing the game | Facilitating a session
5. Session recap | Next Steps & Retrospective

The approach: Draw on real world experiences of high level solutioning, group problem solving and running a good old game of D&D

An eager facilitator is running towards you! They appear to be armed with a “pick of Ice-breaking”...

- D&D experience?
- What was your favourite characters name?



Puff the Magic Dragonborn Sorcerer
Equipment: Fanny-pack of holding

What is D&D?

- “Fantasy Role-Playing Game” Released in 1974 by **Gary Gygax** and **Dave Arneson**. Currently on 5.5th 2024 edition, now owned by *Wizards of the Coast*
- Players take the role of a hero and embark upon an adventure together
- In person around a table, or virtually online
- Explore locations, solve puzzles, fight monsters, navigate social situations and discover treasure, sinister plots and more!

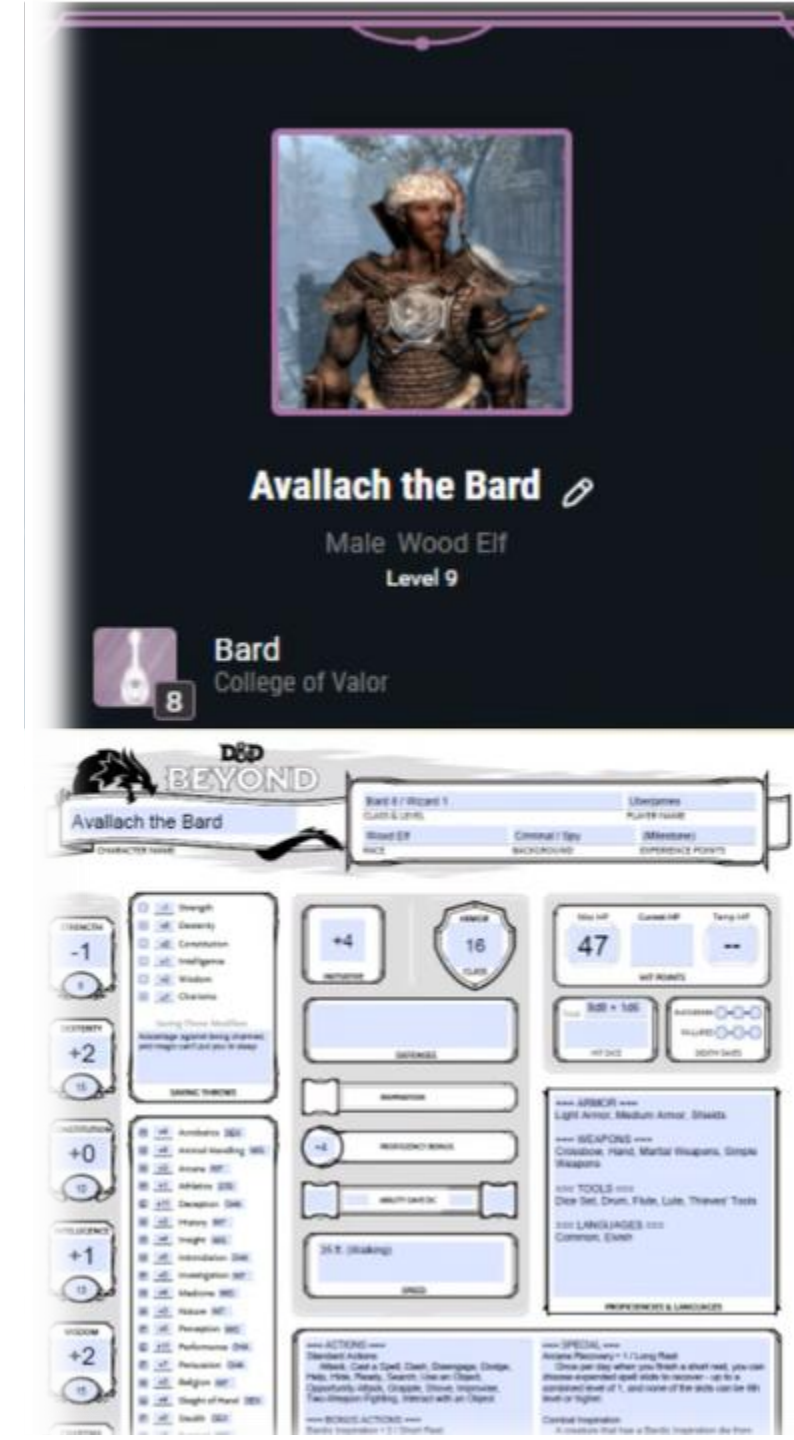


Community S2e14 : Advanced Dungeons & Dragons

Key Stakeholders

Players / Participants

- Each player creates and controls a single character, representing an individual in the fantasy world
- All their information is captured on a character sheet / a resume, skills matrix, DISC profile
- Races / diverse backgrounds: Human, Elf, Dwarf...
- Class / Job titles: Wizard, Bard, Fighter, Paladin...
- Various ability scores, skills, spells
- Name + Backstory



Key Stakeholders

Dungeon Master (DM) / Facilitator

- Author, Director and Referee of the game
- Responsible for narrative flow, acting out characters and controlling enemies
- Maintain the pace, providing feedback while players adventure in the world
- Guide the players through situations, apply the rules and ensure they're having a good time
- Design their own maps and adventures, use a prebuilt campaign or story or a combination



Begin the game, choose your actions wisely...

- Describe, Decide, Roll
- Players and the DM roll dice to determine the success or failure of an action
- The DM determines the difficulty i.e. easy: must roll over a 10 to be successful, hard: roll over 18
- Depending on a character or monsters abilities and skills they may get a bonus to their roll or a penalty
- Example: A strong barbarian might have a +5 to their attack roll to crush an enemy but may not be very charismatic and thus a -5 when engaging in a diplomatic or social interaction
 - Sr. Project Manager produces a charter deliverable: **+7 to PM tasks**
 - Director of HR tries to configure a python deploy script: **unlikely to succeed (but not 0...)**



Dungeons & Data-Flow Diagrams?

How does this relate to facilitating a data workshop, a solutioning or problem solving session?

- The adventure is a combined effort of everyone who plays including the DM, each participant brings their unique skillsets and abilities to contribute towards the adventure and or solution
- The session is a combined effort of everyone who attends including the facilitator, each participant brings their unique skillsets and abilities to contribute towards the session and or solution



“This is the least painful workshop I’ve ever attended”



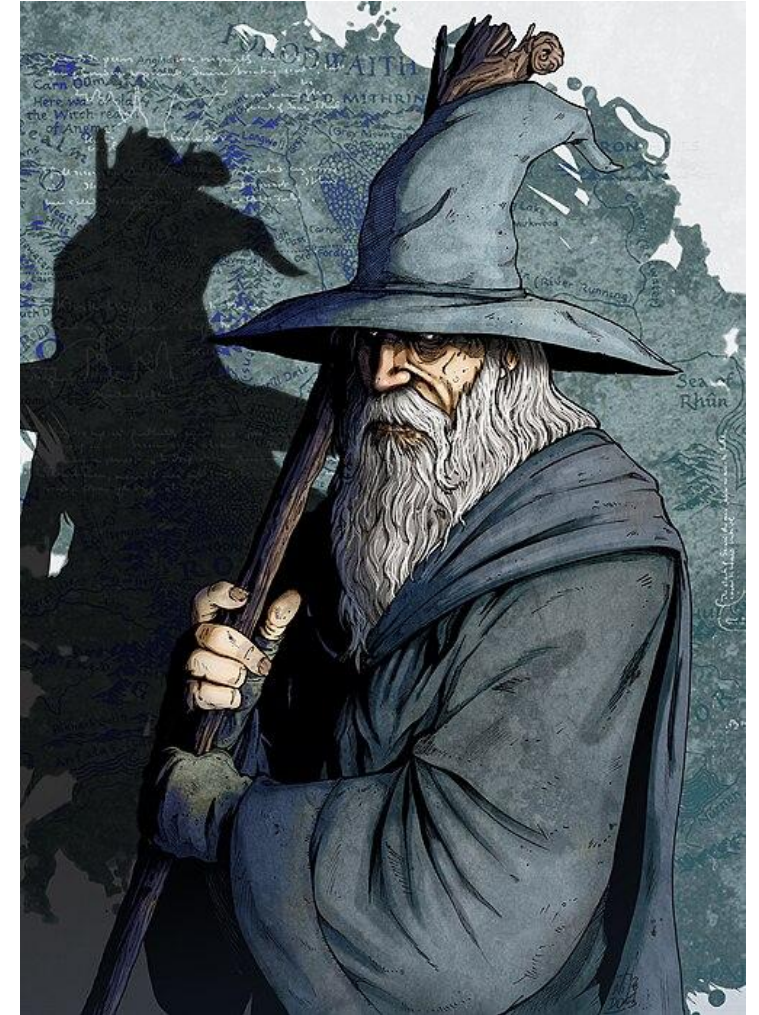
So be it. You shall be the Fellowship of the Ring

- Bringing together the mix of players for D&D and the right participants for a productive workshop or session is key.
- For PSHCP: Business + Technology SME's ranging from 4-25 participants
- For Data SWAT: Technology SME's from each application stack ~10 participants
- For Digital: Marketing, Compliance, Technology etc.
- For D&D: A Bard, Sorcerer, Paladin, Warlock and a Monk
- 4 Developers from the same team?
- 4 Sorcerers taking on a pack of trolls?
- Do you recruit a mercenary or a guide?
- Could you benefit from a fresh set of eyes?



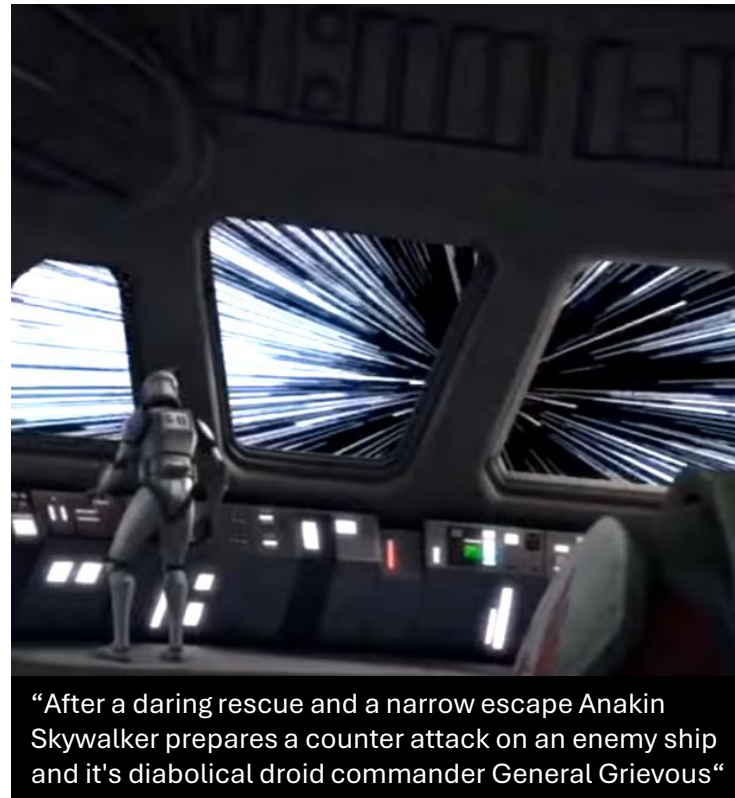
You Shall ~~Not~~, Pass! Set yourself up for success!

- Consider inviting/designating a Yoda or Gandalf
- Someone who can provide direction if we get stalled
- Bounce an idea off of to spur conversation
- This can be the DM or an experienced Player
- This can be the facilitator or a participant
- Project Sponsor, Leader, Subject matter expert, Project/Program Manager, Architect
- For D&D: consult the Sorcerer named Zamodin – Phone a friend



Gandalf the Grey (artwork by Nidoart facebook.com/nidoart)

The Plot Hook & the Pre-Read



"After a daring rescue and a narrow escape Anakin Skywalker prepares a counter attack on an enemy ship and it's diabolical droid commander General Grievous"



You have been identified as a contributor for our solutioning workshops. Your attendance will be required and would be greatly appreciated if you could make yourself available.

Objective: During this workshop we will be responding to the HL requirements with a solution by identifying application and/or business processes impacted. Expected output of this meeting will be to have a HL solution and identify business & application teams to obtain planning estimates.

Supporting documentation:

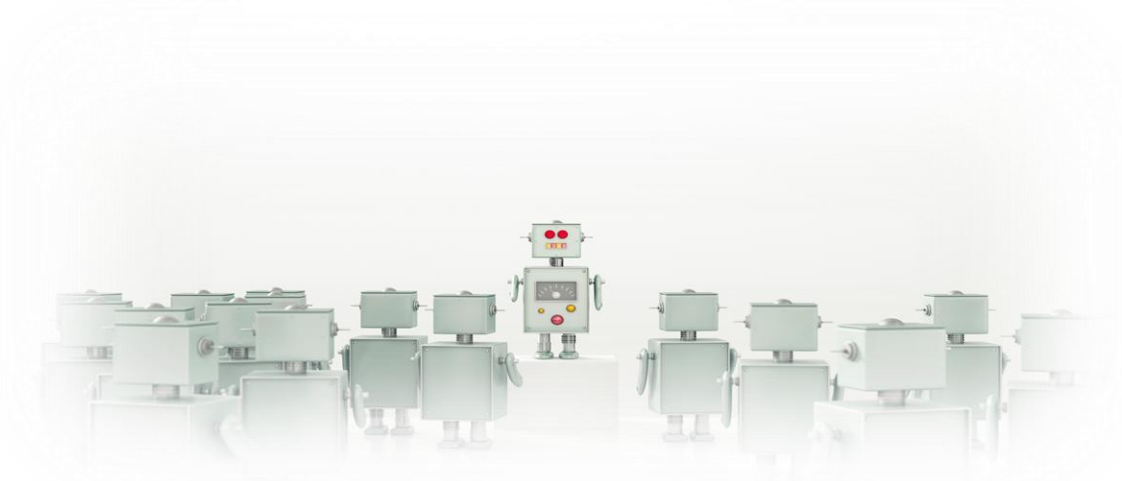
Link to X.pdf

Link to HL Requirements we're reviewing

Please take time to review HL requirements prior to this session.

Take a short rest to regain spell slots & hit points

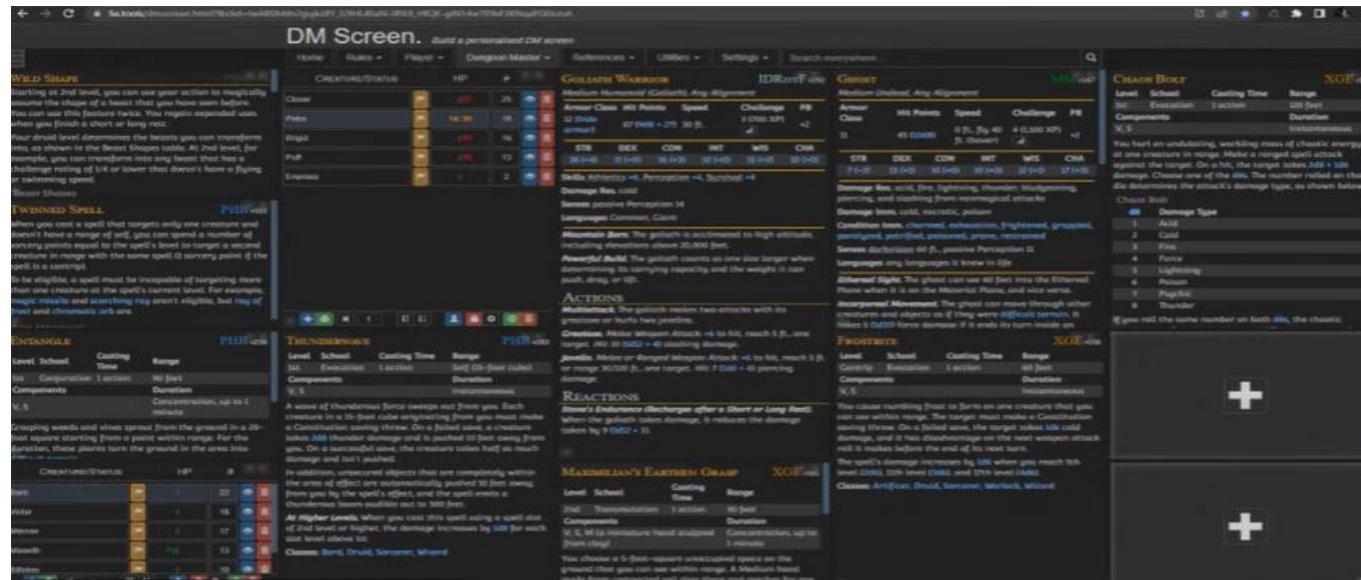
- Humans are not Automatons
- Normalize and Schedule Breaks
- Consider providing snacks, coffee etc.
Does it make sense to bring lunch in?
- Keep to the schedule, anticipate the need for more time – call it out sooner than later



← Today		< > September 14, 2026 ▾	
AB	UTC-5	14 Monday	
			Chug can of sugar-free Red Bull
8 AM	9 AM	High Level Solutioning SOW 3.11	
9 AM	10 AM		
10 AM	11 AM		“quick call”?
			High Level Solutioning SOW 3.5
11 AM	12 PM	High Level Solutioning SOW 3.12	
12 PM	1 PM		
1 PM	2 PM		
2 PM	3 PM		
3 PM	4 PM		

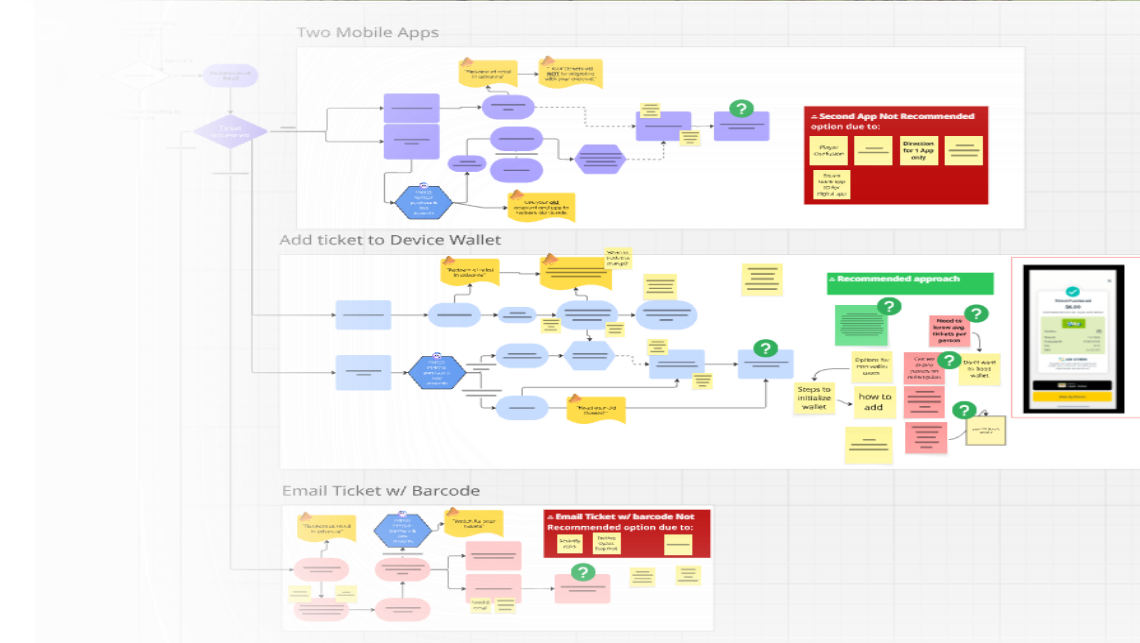
Proper planning prevents piss-poor performance (probably)

- If virtual: second screen (if possible) with supporting information for quick reference
If in person: whiteboard, flipchart, sticky-notes & markers ready to go
- Preparation is extremely important to have a good session
- Try and respect participants time, if folks need to leave early – prioritize them



The entrance to a dark and dingy teams meeting lies before you...

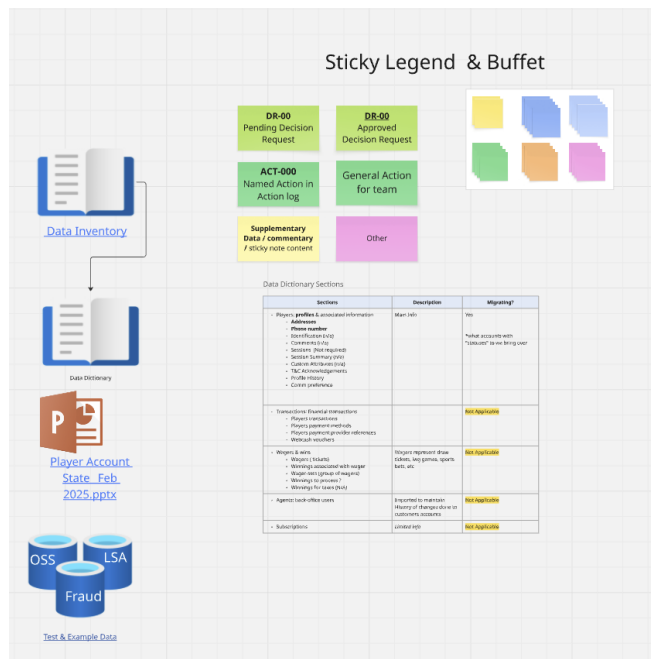
- Prepare the battlefield for your players / participants, have assets at your disposal
- Prepare a “straw dog” or template: PowerPoint, Excel, Confluence, Miro, Visio, Figma, MS Paint
- Give players something to look at and talk about
- Theatre of the mind ? Perhaps not.



Here's X I prepared earlier

Pre-bake your assets

- Have everything anyone might need queued up and ready to go



Getting ready to play

- Personal/professional check-in, How are things going, personally, professionally. Make people feel safe!
- We often buzz right by that and into the agenda for meetings.
- Taking that minute or two before you begin the formal agenda can break the ice
- Dial up candor & creativity set the tone – upbeat and engaging.
- Recap why we're here, roll up our sleeves and get moving!
- Consider leading by example, being a great participant in other meetings give administrative feedback “yes, we can hear you,” “we can see your screen”



Off Camera, on mute?

- Cameras on or Cameras off?
- Roll20 for virtual D&D often turn off cameras for bandwidth reasons, but can be used for acting out an action
- Cameras on can encourage participants to be “Present”
- Hybrid option: turn camera on while speaking
- Going on camera and putting your hand up sometimes shows the presenter.
- Thoughts?



You come across a waterfall in the sewers, the stairs eroded...

Your map shows your objective lies beyond, how do you choose to venture forth. What do you do?

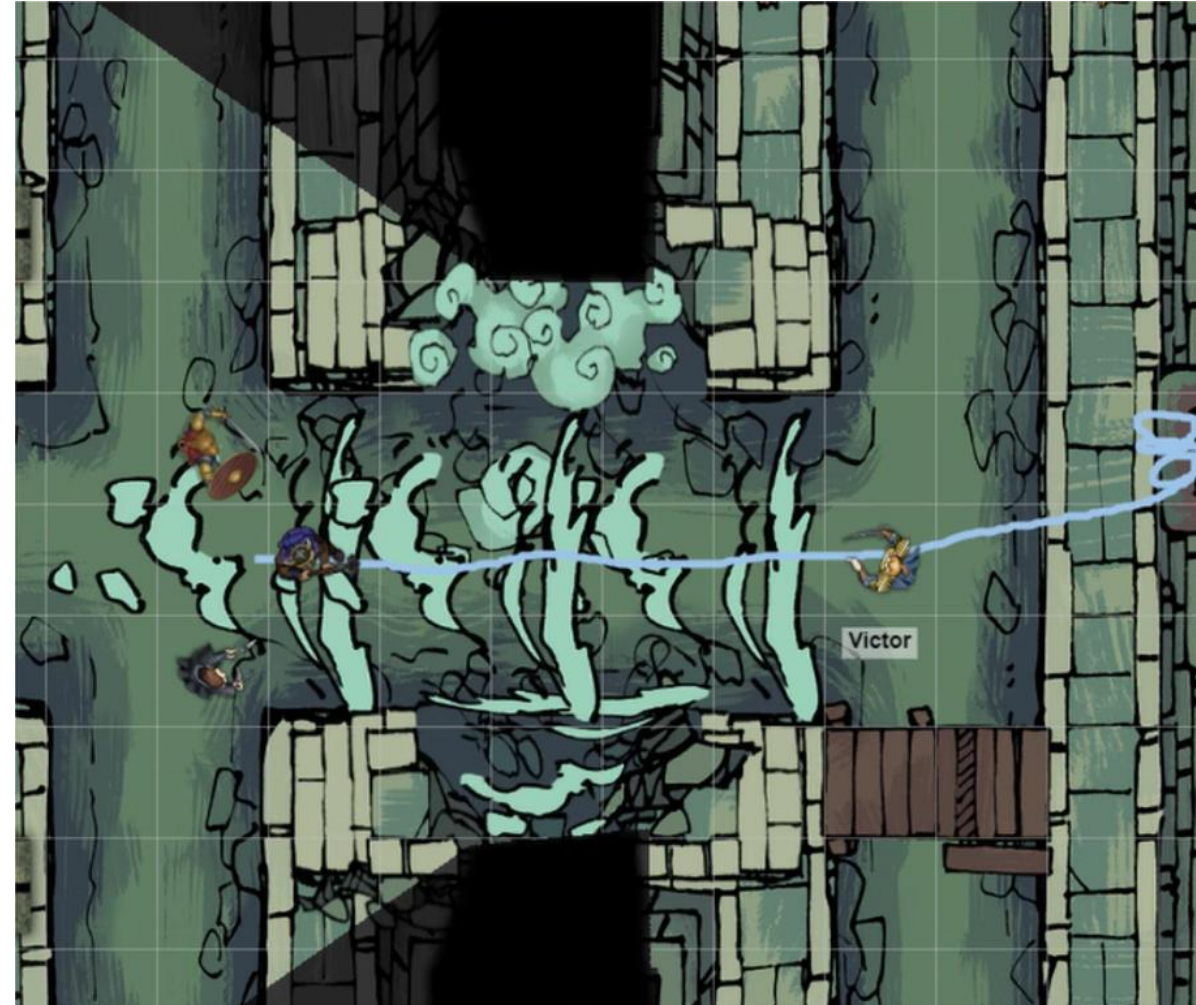
- Define the problem
 - Generate solutions
 - Explore benefits and consequence of each possible solution
 - Implement a solution
 - Evaluate the solution
- Player: “We throw a rope and climb up”
 - DM: “Okay, you can try and do that, walk me through exactly how you’re going to do that”



You pull yourself up through the sludge with the rope!

DM needs to assess how much information is needed at the right level of detail.

- Players notice a pipe that looks sturdy
- The Barbarian pulls out a hemp rope in his pack and attached is a grappling hook
- The Paladin throws the hook (succeeds an athletics check)
- etc. etc.



You notice a broad requirement glimmering in the shallow stream

- Consider a project with hundreds of requirements. Needed to apply high level solutions against requirements for assessing t-shirt size of work for the purposes of planning.
- DM Facilitator needs to assess how much information is needed at the right level of detail – Let's talk about the narrative- tell the story of what we're working through.
- Guide the team through:
 - Define the problem
 - Generate solutions
 - Explore benefits and consequence of each possible solution
 - Implement a solution
 - Evaluate the solution

Solution request:	Proposed solution:	Considerations:
Develop and implement infrastructure and process to consume weekly files from vendor to process updates	(SFTP) File transfer, luck, magic & something about a cron job?	Sure hope no one changes the format of the file or we'll have a bad time

You discover a high level solution!

- Similar to the rope, the team came up with various steps involved in solutioning against the requirement or the problem that needs to be solved.
- Now who's going to roll the intelligence check to put together an estimate?
- Before moving on, asses comfort level – are we making any huge assumptions, do we need to add a caveat, document any risks ?
- Importantly, who owns the next step, is there an action item or further investigation?
- The players didn't think to pull up the rope, when they returned it was soaked, slimy and made the return trip hazardous.

Table talk

- Keeping track of your players / participants
- Have we heard from Jeremy lately?
- This sounds like a opportunity for Architecture to chime in
- Give them a space to voice their thoughts and opinions
- Enforce a turn order (Roll for initiative)
- Participant agency
 - Ability to influence the story / take control of the workshop
- As a DM you speak as different characters – you prepare accordingly
- As a facilitator you may need to think as different rolls “ Putting my developer cap on..”
- Be wary of deliberation & decision-making:
 - Democracy vs. Single-Leader vs. “I’ve already chosen”
 - Try different ways to call on people.
 - Jason... (wait for them to stop multi-tasking) .. What do you think about X...
 - Meowtholomew (wait for them to finish eating their dinner) ... a goblin hurls a spear at you, how do you react



I took the road less traveled – and now I’m lost

Inevitable derailment & circle back

- Set yourself up for success, have a mechanism to capture action items to be handled outside of the session
- Guide your players back to the main narrative, consider having them make a note in their journals to return to that cave / area when they have more information



Action Items 02-02-2021 — Enrolment Education Workshop				
Meeting attendees: Person A, Person B, Person C, Person D, Person E, Person F, Person G, Person H				
#	Action	Prime	Target Completion Date	Notes
1	Provide 'sample' material for enrolment team communiques	Person F	Complete	Attached document
2	Prepare draft communique on behalf of leadership	Person D	Complete	Shared with team for feedback
3	Provide feedback/changes to draft communique	Person A, Person B, Person C, Person E, Person F, Person G, Person H	06-Feb-21	
4	Share draft with leadership, make arrangements for communique to be issued	Person H, Person D	12-Feb-21	Sent heads-up. Need to confirm distribution list, translations, and any additional requirements.
5	Send out FR/ENG communique to target audience	Person H, Leadership Representative	28-Feb-21	Note: Additional support available if needed.
6	Key Data points are:	All	On-going	Key data points include: First Name, Last Name

Let's circle back.. Equipped with knowledge and upgraded weapons



Big differences ?

- In D&D we roll to see if an action succeeds or fails. In most cases, we're looking to avoid Critical Failures at all costs!
- D&D Sessions are for the purpose of moving the players along a narrative for fun! You can go off script, you can go over time with little negative impact on the end results.
- No established hierarchy or roles in D&D, generally decisions need to be made collectively vs having key decision makers determine the outcome of certain narratives.

Return to the quest giver for your reward

- The activity has been completed, Congratulations!
- Provide a quick summary of what was discussed
- Be wary of AI transcripts – check for accuracy
- Send it out for review for the team to look at with fresh eyes – not a review, but confirmation.
- Regroup if needed (Targeted group)

Maybe the real
treasure was the
assumptions we
validated along the
way



Questions ?

Comments !

Heckles !?

